World's Afire

By Paul B. Janeczko

Sam Tuttle, Camera Operator

I still remember that day,
how hot it was
even before the fire.
I brought my new 8mm movie camera
to see how it'd work
to see if I could catch something special.

I filmed the midway
the menagerie
scenes filled with smiling faces
kids shrieking for joy
jabbering with excitement
hawkers selling souvenirs.

I never had time to see the show.
I was aiming my camera
at the tent.
smiling
as I zoomed in and out
to capture the size of the big top.
That's when I saw the corner
of the tent flash into flames.

4NG Fanatics

Then the screaming started
people streaming from the tent
faces pained with fear
as black smoke blossomed
over the tent
like a tree of death.
I'm not sure
how long I filmed.
Enough to capture too much terror.
I know that.

I watched it once.
Enough to sicken me again.
But when I reversed the film,
killing smoke vanished
flames flickered to nothing
people backed out of the big top
and boys screeched with joy
jabbered in excitement
girls skipped and twirled
in their summer dresses
mothers smiled to see their children
joyous
all in silence,
none knowing
they would be this happy
for the last time
in their lives.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

INTRODUCTION

On Thursday, July 6, 1944, as the afternoon performance of the Ringling Bros. and Barnum & Bailey Circus in Hartford. Connecticut had just begun; fire broke out in the southwest corner of the big top. The fire was fast and angry, killing 167 people - mostly women and children - in a matter of minutes. World's Afire by Paul B. Janeczko brings this day vividly back to life through the eyes of those affected by the blaze.

Bill Conti, Parent

I yanked Danny
through the crowd.
Packed together,
we surged
except for those who fainted.
They got stepped on.
Couldn't help it
though I tried.
Dannv was crying
when we reached the chute.
I tossed him
over to the other side
yelled for him to run
to meet me at the car.
He wailed but went.
I couldn't.
Not then
not with all the other kids
looking like small frantic dolls.
So I started tossing them
over the chute.
I didn't have to tell them to run.
I climbed atop the chute
grabbing any small hand
raised my way.
I just hauled them –
couldn't count how many
up and over.
Up and over.
Until my foot slipped.
I lost mv balance,
went down.
The crowd dragged me under
even though I raised mv hand
for help.

Dennis Mortimer, Firefighter

We laid nine hundred feet of hose
then another hundred and a half.
About a ton of hose.
But we all knew
we were too late.
There was no tent

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

just folding chairs
and bleachers blazing
like nobody's business.
Too hot to get close
See, they dip
their chairs in paint
and hang the up to dry,
so as the years pass
they're adding another layer of paint
eager to burn
But that's not half the problem
of the tent itself.
To keep the rain out
they coat the canvas
with paraffin mixed with gasoline,
laid on good and thick with stiff brooms.
Oh, that waterproofs it all right -
been doing it that way for years -
but what does it give you?
One huge candle
just waiting for a light.

William Harvey, State Trooper

As the bodies arrived at the armory
I tied green casualty tags to their toes.
We separated the bodies by sex
as best as we could tell
setting each on a sagging army cot.
Mostly women, though,
and older girls
filled three rows.
We put the children in one corner,
men in the middle.
Then I wrote a list for each victim:
any clothes or jewelry,
scars, tattoos,
dental work.
Anything that would help.

A soldier covered each corpse
with an olive drab blanket
as those searching lined up outside
in the shade of the elms.

When they came
searching for their dead,
thev were escorted
by a state trooper and a nurse
to the area most likely to hold
their loved ones.
Nurses carried smelling salts.
We had three first-aid stations.
A rolling cart with coffee.
There was little noise.
Shuffling feet. sobs mainly.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The lucky ones found their dead
in the first few rows of cots
before they got to the back rows
where bodies looked
like solemn museum statues
except faceless and black.

I had pity for the searchers
who couldn't recognize their dead
and needed to start
the march
again
at the first cot
shuffling and sobbing.

Dr. Rose Beekman, Fire Expert

Surprised?
Oh. I'm sure
they were surprised
that the fire spread
so fast.
a runaway train.
Roared like one, too.
How fast did it spread?
Let me put it this way:
some didn't have time

4NG Fanatics

to scream for help
before flames shot up
the side of the tent
like a dragon roaring to life.

Did they have a chance?
Not really.
Not the ones closest to the fire.
It'd be like surviving a volcano.
Hair sizzled.
Skin burned.
The tent became a chimney,

How long did it last?
Six minutes. Mavhe ten.
Yes. I'm sure.
But for most it lasted
only long enough
to have the breath burned out of them.
Most of them were dead
long before black chunks of tent
fell on their bodies
like pieces of night.

Sallv Weissman, Nurse

Nothing I'd seen in the ER
for seventeen years prepared me.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I'd seen burn victims
but these people . . .
I even thought -
God help me for saying it -
that the dead were the lucky ones.
It wasn't just the wounds -
the skin hanging off in sheets
peeled patches red as a good steak,
wounds weeping -
but the sounds -
children crying
parents wailing
shouting," Help my baby!" –
the smell
of roasted flesh.
But there is always one case -
ask any of the girls in the ER –
that breaks your heart
wide open.
One woman
her face smudged
but hard with fear
grabbed my wrist
as I rushed by.
"Please," she said,
"check on mv son.
He's my only one."
I had other patients to sec

4NG Fanatics

but she wouldn't let go of my wrist
until I promised
to look for her boy.
I found him among the other children
just as his last breath puffed out.
I held my breath
let it out
brought it back
before I reported the death to a doctor
who'd inform the mother.
Hospital policy.
Which I was glad for,
not having the heart
to not tell her
I was there
for his final sigh.

Thomas Gallagher
Detective, Hartford Police Department

Her face caught my eye.
She was pretty
mavbe six
about the age of my son.
Her green toe tag read # 1565.
Untouched by the fire
except for a burn
on her neck and face.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Blond hair,
shoulder length and curly.
I pictured her blue eyes.
Wearing black patent leather shoes
part of a white flowered dress,
she was placed in the first row
because everybody thought
she would be the first
one claimed.
She wasn't.
Over 175 went before her.
In fact, no one came for Little Miss 1565.
Except William LeBlanc.
He took her
to Morrisette Funeral Home
where they cleaned her face
combed her hair.
took two more pictures,
just in case.
Two days later, they laid her in a small white coffin.
the last one available.
No one came for her.
Le Blanc drove her to Northwood Cemetery
through the black iron arch
past rows of empty graves,
marked with gray stones
telling tales of men
who died far from home

4NG Fanatics

Killed in Action
Missing at Sea -
their bodies as gone
as their hopes in life.

With all the burials -
fiftv-four at Northwood –
the gravediggers
weary and sweating
needed to do
some final digging
while a solemn crowd waited.
A reverend read the Twentv-third Psalm.
A rabbi read the Kaddish.
A priest read in Latin,
sprinkled holy water.

In the sun
I waited with her
while the others left.
Even as she was lowered
into the ground
and dirt thumped on her coffin
no one came for her.
In the sun
I waited with her.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Paul B. Janeczko
ISBN: 978-0763622350
Publisher: Candlewick
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2020 National Qualifier - MS
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY